

Reciprocity

What is it?

People naturally feel a need to return the favour when they receive value first.

History

One of the oldest persuasion patterns studied in social psychology since the 1960s.

The Psychology Behind It

Humans are wired to return kindness to maintain social balance.

When someone receives something valuable upfront, they feel obligated to give something back — which makes reciprocity extremely powerful in persuasion and UX.

This is why value-first experiences often outperform direct selling.

Why It Matters

- Builds goodwill and loyalty
- Improves engagement
- Drives organic sharing
- Strengthens brand trust

How to Apply It

- Offer value first (free guides, free trials, free tools)
- Reward meaningful actions (reviews, shares, referrals)
- Show generosity clearly in the interface
- Keep it genuine and not manipulative

Theory in Action

Dropbox gives free storage when users refer friends — the brand gives first, the user returns value.

Costco offers free food samples — this boosts instant trust and drives higher purchase intent.

Final Thought

When you give first, people naturally want to give back.

Lead with generosity. It strengthens relationships, trust, and conversions.